If you are a fan of puréed soups, you can process the mixture in a blender at the end of cooking, then pass it though a fine sieve and reheat gently before serving.

cream of asparagus soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 10 MINS **COOK** 40 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS AT THE END OF STEP 3

1 quart (1 liter) water
salt and freshly ground black pepper
4 tbsp butter
1lb 2oz (500g) white or green asparagus, trimmed, peeled (reserve the trimmings), and cut into 1in (2.5cm) lengths
1¼ cups milk
4 tbsp flour
pinch of sugar
pinch of freshly grated nutmeg
2 medium egg yolks
2 tbsp heavy (whipping) cream
1½ tbsp chopped flat-leaf parsley

1 Put the water into a saucepan with 1 level tsp salt and 1½ tbsp of the butter. Add the asparagus trimmings, bring to a boil, then cover and simmer for 15 minutes over medium heat. Strain through a sieve (reserving the cooking liquid) and discard the trimmings.

2 Bring the cooking liquid to a boil and add the trimmed asparagus. Return to a boil, cover, and cook for 10–12 minutes or until *al dente*, then drain, reserving the cooking liquid. Add enough of the milk to the cooking liquid to make 4 cups in all.

3 Melt the remaining butter in a pan, add the flour, and cook over low heat, stirring, for 2–3 minutes or until smooth. Gradually add the milk mixture, stirring vigorously with a whisk to make sure there are no lumps. Bring to a boil and cook, uncovered, over low heat for 5 minutes, stirring occasionally. Add the sugar and nutmeg and season with salt and freshly ground black pepper.

4 Stir the egg yolks into the cream and slowly add the mixture to the soup, stirring carefully to get a smooth texture. Add the asparagus and reheat gently. Do not let the soup boil. Serve garnished with the parsley.